

Focus on the Lord

What does the Bible have to say about the deep inner drive that makes people want to be admired and respected? “Not to us, O Lord, not to us, but to your name give glory, for the sake of your steadfast love and your faithfulness!” ESV (Ps 115:1). Even more than the believers desire for personal glory, believers desire glory for God.

Why do believers want God to receive glory? Why do believers want God’s reputation to be blessed by themselves and others? Notice we are given a reason: “steadfast love” and “faithfulness.” God truly delivers His people. He delivers on His promises and He rescues His people from their difficult circumstances. He does it again and again.

As we come to the end of the story told in the books of Ezra and Nehemiah, we see this faithfulness of God.

Nehemiah 6

¹⁵ So **the wall was finished** on the twenty-fifth day of the month Elul, **in fifty-two days**. ¹⁶ And when all our enemies heard of you it, all the nations around us were afraid and fell greatly in their own esteem, for they perceived that this work had been **accomplished with the help of our God**. **Nehemiah 6:15–16 (ESV)**

Nehemiah 8

¹ And **all the people gathered** as one man into the square before the Water Gate. And they told Ezra the scribe to bring the **Book of the Law of Moses** that the LORD had commanded Israel. ² So Ezra the priest brought the Law before the assembly, both men and women and all who could understand what they heard, on the first day of the seventh month.

³ And he **read from it** facing the square before the Water Gate **from early morning until midday**, in the presence of the men and the women and those who could understand. And **the ears of all the people were attentive to the Book of the Law**.

⁴ And Ezra the scribe stood on a wooden platform that they had made for the purpose. And beside him stood Mattithiah, Shema, Anaiah, Uriah, Hilkiah, and Maaseiah on his right hand, and Pedaiah, Mishael, Malchijah, Hashum, Hashbaddanah, Zechariah, and Meshullam on his left hand.

⁵ And Ezra opened the book in the sight of all the people, for he was above all the people, and as he opened it **all the people stood**. ⁶ And Ezra blessed the LORD, the great God, and all the people answered, “Amen, Amen,” lifting up their hands. And **they bowed their heads** and **worshiped the Lord** with **their faces to the ground**.

⁷ Also Jeshua, Bani, Sherebiah, Jamin, Akkub, Shabbethai, Hodiah, Maaseiah, Kelita, Azariah, Jozabad, Hanan, Pelaiah, the Levites, **helped the people to understand the Law**, while the people remained in their places. ⁸ They read from the book, from the Law of God, clearly, and they gave the sense, so that the people understood the reading.

⁹ And **Nehemiah**, who was the governor, and Ezra the priest and scribe, and the Levites who taught the people **said to all the people**, “This day is holy to the LORD your God; **do not mourn or weep**.” **For all the people wept as they heard the words of the Law**.

¹⁰ Then he said to them, **“Go your way. Eat the fat and drink sweet wine and send portions to anyone who has nothing ready, for this day is holy to our Lord. And do not be grieved, for the joy of the Lord is your strength.”** ¹¹ So the Levites calmed all the people, saying, “Be quiet, for this day is holy; do not be grieved.” ¹² And **all the people went their way** to eat and drink and to send portions and **to make great rejoicing**, because **they had understood** the words that were declared to them. **Nehemiah 8:1–12 (ESV)**

Philippians 4

⁴ **Rejoice in the Lord always**; again I will say, rejoice. ⁵ Let your reasonableness be known to everyone. The Lord is at hand; ⁶ do not be anxious about anything, but **in everything by prayer and supplication with thanksgiving let your requests be made known to God**. ⁷ And the peace of God, which surpasses all understanding, **will guard your hearts and your minds** in Christ Jesus. ⁸ Finally, brothers, whatever is true, whatever is honorable, whatever is just, whatever is pure, whatever is lovely, whatever is commendable, if there is any excellence, if there is anything worthy of praise, think about these things. **Philippians 4:4-8 (ESV)**

² **looking to Jesus**, the founder and perfecter of our faith, **who for the joy that was set before him endured the cross, despising the shame**, and is seated at the right hand of the throne of God. **Hebrews 12:2 (ESV)**

¹¹ and to aspire to **live quietly, and to mind your own affairs**, and to work with your hands, as we instructed you, **1 Thessalonians 4:11 (ESV)**

Wherever you get onto the train of glory ...

Whenever you get on the train to glory ...

It's still going to glory.

Rejoice in your destination, not where you've been.

Rejoice in the savior who travels along beside you, not the tormentors left behind.

Rejoice in what God is doing to make His plan a reality for you. He's including you in His plans and dreams.

The path to glory leads to a life with God that will last forever. That will be glory.